

Converting Carillon 7.2.4 to Version 8.1

User-facing database conversion instructions for Westminster Chimes and Carillon Bells 8.1

Prepared for version 8.1 portable installations

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Purpose

This guide explains how to upgrade an existing Carillon 7.2.4 database so it can be used by Westminster Chimes and Carillon Bells version 8.1. The conversion keeps the existing playlist, seasonal groups, settings, email information, and song paths, then adds the database structures required by version 8.1.

Important: Do not run the main Carillon program while the database conversion is being performed. Close Carillon first, then run the conversion utility.

What the Conversion Utility Does

- Creates a dated backup copy of the selected database before changing it.
- Converts Random Music Directory Rotation from the old one-row format to the version 8.1 seven-slot row format.
- Creates the Silence Schedule table and adds twelve disabled silence windows.
- Adds any missing settings fields expected by version 8.1.
- Copies seasonal group date ranges and the main group play time into matching playlist songs so group play times appear on the main screen.
- Normalizes stored time values so seconds are preserved and displayed correctly.
- Writes a conversion report to the logs folder on the portable drive.

Before You Begin

1. Make sure you know where the existing Carillon 7.2.4 database is located. In a normal portable installation it is in the databases folder and is named carillon.db.
2. Close Carillon completely. If the main program is running, the database may be locked or changed while the converter is working.
3. Keep a separate copy of the old portable drive or old database if possible. The converter also makes its own automatic backup, but an outside backup is good practice before a version upgrade.
4. Prepare the version 8.1 portable folder or flash drive. The main program must still be launched from the portable drive root after conversion.

Step-by-Step Conversion

5. Open the version 8.1 portable drive or folder in File Explorer.
6. Start the conversion utility, CarillonDBUpgrade724To81.exe. The utility should be run from the portable drive root when possible so the report is written to the correct logs folder.

7. Click Browse and select the database to upgrade. For a normal portable install, select databases\carillon.db.
8. Check the status line. A 7.2.4 database should be reported as the wide random-directory format. If the utility reports 8.1-compatible, the database already has the version 8.1 structures.
9. Read the confirmation text, then check the confirmation box.
10. Click Back Up and Upgrade.
11. Wait for the utility to report that the upgrade is complete. Do not close the program or remove the flash drive while the upgrade is running.
12. Note the backup file and report file shown by the utility.

Files Created by the Conversion

File or folder	Purpose
databases\backup\carillon7_2_4_before_8_1_upgrade_YYYYMMDD_HHNNSS.db	Automatic copy of the database before conversion.
logs\DatabaseUpgrade_724_to_81_YYYYMMDD_HHNNSS.txt	Conversion report showing what was checked and changed.
PL_RAND_DIR_ROTATION_WIDE_BACKUP table inside the database	Preserved copy of the old random-directory wide table.
silence_schedule table inside the database	Version 8.1 silence windows, initially disabled.

After the Conversion

13. Start Carillon 8.1 from the portable drive root, such as F:\Carillon.exe, start_carillon.vbs, or start_carillon.bat.
14. Open the main screen and confirm the playlist loads.
15. Open Group Maintenance and confirm seasonal group dates and play times are present.
16. Select a song in a seasonal group and confirm the matching play date range and first play time appear on the main screen.
17. Open Random Music Directory Rotation and confirm all seven slots are visible. Slot 1 is the default; slots 2 through 7 are date-window override folders.
18. Open Silence Schedule and confirm twelve silence windows are available and disabled unless you intentionally enable one.
19. Use Show Remaining Schedule to confirm today's schedule is reasonable before enabling unattended playback.

If Something Goes Wrong

- If the utility says the database cannot be opened, close Carillon and try again. Also confirm the selected file is the actual database file, not a shortcut or a folder.
- If the utility reports a missing playlist or seasonal group table, stop and do not keep trying different files. The selected file may not be a Carillon 7.2.4 database.
- If the upgrade fails after the backup is created, keep the report file and use the backup database in databases\backup to restore the pre-conversion data.
- If the main program cannot find the database after conversion, close it and restart Carillon from the portable drive root.

Caution: The converter is intended for 7.2.4 databases. If a database already reports as 8.1-compatible, do not repeatedly run the converter unless you are intentionally rechecking the database with a backup in place.

What Is Preserved

- Playlist rows and song paths are preserved. Full audio paths are not stripped.
- Seasonal group names, date ranges, and play times are preserved and copied to matching playlist rows.
- Email and application settings are preserved where present.
- Random directory slot values are preserved and moved into the version 8.1 row-based slot table.
- Existing logs are not part of the database conversion and are left alone.

Technical Summary for Support

Area	Version 8.1 conversion action
PL_RAND_DIR_ROTATION	Renames the old wide table, creates the row-based table, and inserts slots 1 through 7.
silence_schedule	Creates the table and inserts 12 disabled silence-window rows.
PL_SETTINGS	Adds missing version 8.1 settings columns when needed.
playlist and seasonalgroups	Copies group dates and main play time from seasonalgroups into matching playlist rows.
time values	Normalizes supported time fields so seconds are retained.

Final Checklist

- Database backup exists in databases\backup.
- Conversion report exists in logs.
- Carillon 8.1 starts from the portable drive root.
- Groups, random music, silence schedule, and remaining schedule display correctly.
- The schedule is enabled only after the converted data has been reviewed.